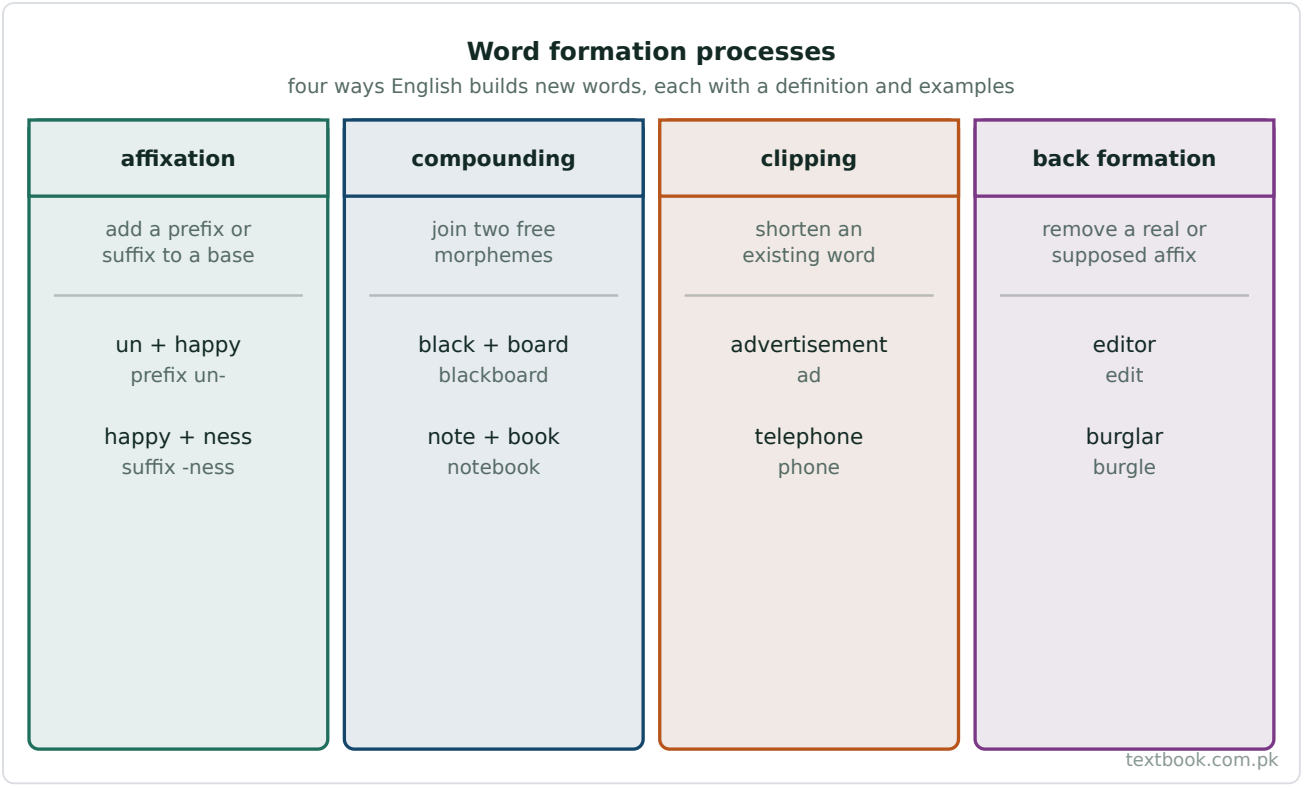
Draft - expert review pending

This unit is complete and passes the platform’s automated checks, but no reviewer has read it yet. Treat its sources and claims with care.

Topic 1.2 - Building words and sentences

A real classroom situation



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Mr Tariq teaches Class 7 English in a government school in Multan. He writes "unhappiness" on the board and asks his pupils what it means. One pupil says it means "not happy". Mr Tariq asks how they knew. The pupil says "un means not, and ness makes it a noun". This topic is about the processes that build words and the structures that build sentences.

Explanation

English has over a million words, but most of them are built from a much smaller set of parts. Understanding how words are formed helps you decode unfamiliar vocabulary. Understanding how sentences are built helps you write with clarity and variety.

Word-formation processes

The four sentence structures

each structure shown with an example and its clause count

Structure	Example	Clause count
simple one independent	The students read the text.	1 independent 0 dependent
compound two independent	The students read the text, and they discussed it.	2 independent 0 dependent
complex one of each	When the students read the text, they discussed it.	1 independent 1 dependent
compound- complex	When the students read the text, they discussed it, and they wrote notes.	2 independent 1 dependent

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The figure above maps the four main processes this topic describes.

Affixation is the addition of a prefix (at the beginning) or a suffix (at the end) of a word. "Un-happiness" adds the prefix "un-" and the suffix "-ness" to the root "happy". English has over a hundred common prefixes and suffixes. Learning the most common ones (un-, re-, pre-, dis-, -ment, -tion, -ly, -ful, -less) gives you access to thousands of words.

Compounding is joining two or more words to create a new one. "Blackboard", "textbook", "notebook" and "keyboard" are all compounds. Some compounds are written as one word, some as two, and some with a hyphen. The meaning of a compound is usually (but not always) related to the meanings of its parts.

Clipping is the shortening of a word. "Exam" (examination), "lab" (laboratory), "phone" (telephone) and "maths" (mathematics) are all clippings. They are common in informal English and are often the form that Pakistani learners encounter first.

Back formation is the creation of a new word by removing what looks like an affix but is not. "Edit" was formed from "editor" (not the other way around), and "televise" from "television". Back formations are a sign of a living language that is still changing.

Sentence structures

A sentence is a group of words that expresses a complete thought. English has four main sentence structures, and the figure above maps them with examples.

A simple sentence has one independent clause: a subject and a verb that express a complete thought. "The pupils read their books." A simple sentence can be long ("The pupils in Class 7 read their English books quietly during the free period") but it still has only one clause.

A compound sentence has two or more independent clauses joined by a coordinating conjunction (and, but, or, so, yet, for, nor). "The pupils read their books and the teacher wrote on the board." Each clause could stand alone as a sentence.

A complex sentence has one independent clause and one or more dependent clauses (clauses that cannot stand alone). "When the bell rang, the pupils packed their bags." "When the bell rang" is a dependent clause; it needs the independent clause to complete its meaning.

A compound-complex sentence has at least two independent clauses and at least one dependent clause. "When the bell rang, the pupils packed their bags and the teacher left the room." This is the most common structure in academic writing.

Common misconception. "Longer sentences are better sentences." They are not. The best sentence is the one that communicates the clearest meaning. A mix of simple, compound and complex sentences produces the most readable writing.

Activity: Analyse word formation and sentence structure

Work in groups of three. Take a short English newspaper article (or a textbook paragraph). First, identify five words formed by affixation, compounding, clipping or back formation, and explain the process. Second, identify five sentences and classify each as simple, compound, complex or compound-complex. Allow 25 minutes. Then present and compare with another group.

Check your understanding

1. Name the four word-formation processes and give one example of each. *(Remember)*
2. A pupil writes, "The teacher gave us a homework about the exam." Identify the clipping in this sentence and explain its full form. *(Understand)*
3. Classify the following sentence as simple, compound, complex or compound-complex: "After the rain stopped, the children went outside and played in the mud." *(Apply)*
4. A friend says, "If I would have known, I would have come earlier." Identify the error in the conditional structure and explain the rule. *(Analyze)*
5. Explain why "edit" is an example of back formation, not affixation. *(Understand)*

Summary

Word-formation processes (affixation, compounding, clipping, back formation) explain how English builds new words from existing parts. Sentence structures (simple, compound, complex, compound- complex) explain how clauses combine to create meaning. Understanding both helps you decode unfamiliar vocabulary and write with clarity and variety.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- [ ] I can identify the four word-formation processes and give an example of each.
- [ ] I can distinguish simple, compound, complex and compound-complex sentences.
- [ ] I can explain how affixation and compounding create new words.
- [ ] I can classify sentences by their structure.
- [ ] I can identify back formations and explain why they are not affixation.

Try this at your practicum school

Collect a page of English textbook material used by the class you are observing. Identify ten words formed by affixation, compounding, clipping or back formation, and ten sentences of different structures. Write half a page on which structures are most common in the textbook and what that tells you about the level of the pupils.

Summative task

Write 300 to 350 words on the following.

> A pupil writes: "The teacher was teaching us about the prefixes and suffixes. She told us that we can make new words by adding letters before or after the root word. I think it is very helpful for learning vocabulary." Using this topic's account of word-formation processes, rewrite this paragraph so that it includes examples of all four processes (affixation, compounding, clipping, back formation) and uses at least one example of each sentence structure (simple, compound, complex, compound-complex).

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Coverage of the four processes (Understand)	Includes all four with correct examples

Criterion	What a strong response does
Coverage of the four structures (Understand)	Includes all four with correct examples
Accuracy of examples (Apply)	**Each example correctly illustrates the process or structure it claims to**
Register and clarity	Writes for a colleague, defines any technical term used, stays within the word count

Further reading

- Swan, M. *Practical English Usage.* (guide recommended)
- Azar, B. S. *Understanding and Using English Grammar.* (guide recommended)

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

Give feedback